

## **Mississippi 8 Conference 7th and 8th Grade Football Policies**

1. Coaches need to remember to coach ethically. In games where the score becomes one-sided, the coach of the team that is ahead, should do all that they possibly can to prevent the experience of the losing team from becoming more difficult than necessary. Coaches of the team in the lead in one-sided games, should avoid passing the ball, running trick plays or reverses, etc. Remember, all of us are working with very young athletes. There is no place for crushing the morale of the losing team in middle school football. Coaches should **also avoid** using players in both A and B games **whenever possible!!** In situations where the number of players available warrants playing players in both games, make sure to play only your lesser skilled A kids in a B game.
2. No game shall be originally scheduled beyond the MEA break. Teams may schedule make-up games the week after MEA if both schools desire to do so. It is recommended that the first practice take place one week before school starts, so that the first scheduled game can occur on the Thursday of the second week of school.
3. Games will be played on Tuesdays and Thursdays with a 4:00 p.m. start. This time may be adjusted per school. With mutual agreement between schools, the games may be played side-by-side, if there are adequate numbers of coaches. This should be communicated between the activities directors on a week by week basis.
4. Tennis shoes, molded rubber shoes or removable cleat shoes may be used, **no** metal cleats.
5. Seventh (7th) and eighth (8th) grade teams shall be determined by an "A" and "B" squad. Schools are free to determine how to divide up A and B, but it is recommended that the distinction be based mostly on ability. No weight limit for 8A, 8B, and 7A levels. There is a weight limit at the 7B grade level for any offensive position that is eligible to carry the ball of 120 pounds at the B level. Players larger than these weight limits at the 7B level may not carry the ball, play quarterback, or receive the ball. They are not allowed to be the return man on punts or kickoffs either. Players bigger than this weight limit, may be on a return team, but must be on the front line. If a kick or punt should happen to go to them on the front line, they may then run with it.
6. Visiting teams must be given a minimum ten (10) minute warm-up period.
7. Two officials should be provided for every game when possible.

8. Games shall consist of four quarters of 15 minutes run time if the two games are being played back-to-back and 20 minutes of run time if the two games are being played side-by-side. In both situations, the last two minutes of each half shall be regular stopped time.

9. Time outs - three (3) per half.

10. Tie games **will not** be played off.

11. The offensive team may use their own ball - intermediate size should be used in 7th grade and either intermediate or official size may be used in 8th grade.

12. On offense, unbalanced lines can be used at the 7th and 8th grade levels

13. Officials will allow reasonable time for the defense to set up prior to the offensive snap of the ball. There shall be no more than 30 seconds from the time the ball is spotted for play until the next offensive snap. Officials should warn offending teams before penalizing them for delay of game.

14. No blitzing will be allowed at any level of play in the 7th and 8th grades. Outside linebackers may cross the line of scrimmage to tackle a quarterback only if the quarterback rolls outside of the offensive tackles.

15. Six man fronts are prohibited at the 7th and 8th grade levels except in short yardage situations. Short yardage situations defined here as anything three yards or less to go. Defensive backs and linebackers must line up in normal positions (3yds for LB and 5yds for DB) except on short yardage (3 yds or less) or goal line situations. In short yardage or goal line situations, the linebackers may line up one yard behind the defensive line. The intent of this is to keep defensive teams from stacking the line of scrimmage with more than six (6) players.

16. In 7th and 8th grade play, there will be no rushing of the punter (dead ball until the ball is kicked - no movement by anyone until the ball is punted). Teams must declare if they are going to punt. The long snapper must snap the ball between his legs. The ball must be punted (if the punter fumbles the snap, he must kick the ball from the spot where he picks it up). Beginning in October at the 8<sup>th</sup> grade level (both A and B), punts will be live. Defenses may rush the punter with a maximum of five players, but may not touch the long snapper until after the punt is in the air. Starting in October at the 8<sup>th</sup> grade level (both A and B), the offensive team no longer needs to declare if they are punting and may fake punts if they wish.

17. Kick offs: per varsity rules.

18. One coach may be on the field during the entire season for 7th grade games. One coach may be on the field through the month of September for 8th grade games

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